

In the Census of Population and Housing -2012, the areas referred to as the Estate Sector correspond to what is identified as the Estate Rural sector in 2024. In 2012, the Estate Rural Sector population accounted for 4.4 percent of the total population, while in the 2024 Census this percentage has declined to 4 percent.

Furthermore, most of the population in Sri Lanka resides in the Rural sector, accounting for 78.5 percent of the total population. This represents an increase of 1.1 percentage points compared to the population reported in the 2012 Census.

Table 3.6 presents the distribution of district population according to urban, rural, estate urban and estate rural sectors in the 2024 census.

Table 3.6 : Population Distribution by District and Sector, 2024

District	Total Population		Sector							
			Urban		Estate Urban		Rural		Estate Rural	
	Number	%	Number	%	Number	%	Number	%	Number	%
Sri Lanka	21,781,800	100.0	3,807,135	17.4	12,068	0.1	17,096,918	78.5	865,679	4.0
Colombo	2,375,415	100.0	1,773,222	74.6	3,874	0.2	593,669	25.0	4,650	0.2
Gampaha	2,436,142	100.0	350,441	14.4	-	-	2,085,307	85.6	394	0.0
Kalutara	1,305,784	100.0	149,939	11.5	864	0.1	1,120,942	85.8	34,039	2.6
Kandy	1,461,895	100.0	171,416	11.7	241	0.0	1,208,607	82.7	81,631	5.6
Matale	526,870	100.0	62,848	11.9	-	-	447,122	84.9	16,900	3.2
Nuwara Eliya	725,280	100.0	36,649	5.0	5,666	0.8	308,357	42.5	374,608	51.7
Galle	1,097,372	100.0	135,514	12.3	-	-	944,811	86.1	17,047	1.6
Matara	837,889	100.0	98,886	11.8	-	-	721,903	86.2	17,100	2.0
Hambantota	671,418	100.0	33,918	5.1	-	-	637,442	94.9	58	0.0
Jaffna	594,751	100.0	113,821	19.1	-	-	480,930	80.9	-	-
Mannar	123,756	100.0	24,120	19.5	-	-	99,636	80.5	-	-
Vavuniya	172,312	100.0	28,681	16.6	-	-	143,631	83.4	-	-
Mullaitivu	122,619	100.0	-	-	-	-	122,619	100.0	-	-
Kilinochchi	136,710	100.0	-	-	-	-	136,710	100.0	-	-
Batticaloa	595,918	100.0	166,369	27.9	-	-	429,549	72.1	-	-
Ampara	744,551	100.0	175,516	23.6	-	-	569,035	76.4	-	-
Trincomalee	442,745	100.0	95,599	21.6	-	-	347,146	78.4	-	-
Kurunegala	1,768,156	100.0	31,023	1.8	-	-	1,731,422	97.9	5,711	0.3
Puttalam	818,816	100.0	70,747	8.6	-	-	747,062	91.3	1,007	0.1
Anuradhapura	960,080	100.0	52,737	5.5	-	-	906,885	94.5	458	0.0
Polonnaruwa	447,530	100.0	37,320	8.3	-	-	410,210	91.7	-	-
Badulla	872,307	100.0	72,155	8.3	175	0.0	645,548	74.0	154,429	17.7
Moneragala	527,585	100.0	-	-	-	-	518,967	98.4	8,618	1.6
Ratnapura	1,145,423	100.0	109,964	9.6	1,248	0.1	938,488	81.9	95,723	8.4
Kegalle	870,476	100.0	16,250	1.9	-	-	800,920	92.0	53,306	6.1

According to Table 3.6, the Colombo District has the largest urban population (1,773,222), while the highest rural population is reported from the Gampaha District (2,085,307). When considering the Estate Rural sector (374,608) and the Estate Urban sector (5,666), the highest population in both sectors is reported from the Nuwara Eliya District. As percentages of the total population of Nuwara Eliya District, these figures represent 51.7 percent and 0.8 percent, respectively.